

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a Singaporean newspaper:

To kill or not to kill

Singapore is at a crossroads in its management of wild monkeys, and to cull or not to cull these native animals has emerged as a key question.

Culling, the selective killing of animals to manage their population, continues to provoke debate amongst people over how best to deal with monkeys as well as stray dogs and wild boar.

Complaints about problems caused by monkeys fell sharply from 1,860 instances in 2013 to just 750 last year after a large number of monkeys were culled by The Veterinary Authority (VA). The VA killed about 570 monkeys, about a third of the estimated population during that period. The VA maintains that it only culls animals as a last resort. It has also explained that moving the monkeys is not feasible as that simply transfers the problem from one area to another.

But animal welfare groups in Singapore believe the success of campaigns to get people to stop feeding the monkeys has helped reduce the number of complaints about monkeys, not the culls. They also suggest the use of birth control on females would further help the situation. The government has stressed that birth control can only be part of a wider programme. In Hong Kong, for instance, planting fruit trees to provide more food for monkeys has reduced the number of such complaints.

The government must now decide if it is to embark on another round of culling wild monkeys to alleviate the problem further.

You are in a school debating club. The next debate will be: 'Selective killing should not be used to control animal numbers in Hong Kong.' Your group is meeting to discuss this question. You may want to talk about:

- why governments use selective killing to control animal numbers
- other methods of controlling animal numbers
- whether or not you support culling
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Are you an animal lover?
2. What wild animal would you like to see?
3. How do wild animals cause problems in Hong Kong?
4. What is the best way to control the number of monkeys in Hong Kong?
5. Why do people feed wild animals such as monkeys?
6. Do you think most Hong Kong people are animal lovers?
7. What animals are the most troublesome in Hong Kong?
8. Do people sometimes pay too much attention to animal welfare?